memory, of a great Persian masterpiece by the maestro Bihzad. In a touching entreaty to his son Muhammad Sharif to never forget his Persian roots, Abd al-Samad wrote: ‘At the age of eighty-five, when his strength has gone, his pen has weakened and his eyesight has dimmed, he has agreed to draw from memory as a memento for this album with every detail for his wise, witty, and astute son Sharif Khan, who is happy, fortunate, prosperous and chosen by the memory of the Merciful.’ This painting, called *Two Fighting Camels*, is a lovely example of the Persian school, ‘where technical virtuosity was prized equally with poetic sensibility’, but it was one which would have been considered passé in Mughal India.

Of the extant 116 paintings detailing the period 1560–77,* the very choice of the subject matter is instructive. Twenty-seven paintings depict specific battles, sieges, and engagements, and another twenty-five show arrests, executions, submissions, and overtures of peace. A further twenty-two paintings depict scenes of hunting, including five vibrant double-spreads. Taken together, this group of paintings is an eloquent testimony to the articulation of power and strength in the sixteenth century: the heaving scenes of furious battles showing the enormous power of the empire tempered by the compassionate embracing of the submissive party; the importance of the qumargha as an instrument of political power; the use of animals—elephants, tigers, cheetahs—as thinly veiled metaphors for the conquest and incorporation of dangerous elements into the Mughal Empire. The elemental energy of these pages point to the incessant and ruthless game of strength and diplomacy and brinkmanship that Akbar played to bring him to the point where, in the elusive dawn of Fatehpur Sikri, he could give thanks to God for allowing him to create the enormous empire of his dreams.

The remainder of the paintings are those of court scenes, celebrations, births, and marriages, and a handful of scenes of meditative contemplation, and unexpected turmoil in Akbar’s life. It is in these paintings that the artists contribute most viscerally to the document, adding details of court life that are not mentioned in Abu’l Fazl’s text. Some of these artists would have had first-hand experience of the scenes described, as painters often accompanied the Padshah on his journeys. It is in these unexpected and precious details that a complex and changing court is brought to life. It is a world of colour, texture, and dynamic complexity with its exquisite details of a courtier’s brocaded jama or the graceful movement of the sijda